

Θεόκριτος ὁ Χῖος

Theocritus of Chios Against Aristotle

eul_aid: elk

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)

Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Theocritus of Chios was a sophist and rhetorician of the 4th century BCE. A student of Metrodorus of Chios and possibly Isocrates, he was known as a sharp-tongued political critic. His opposition to Alexander the Great proved fatal. Following the destruction of Thebes in 335 BCE, he quipped that Alexander must have been "badly advised by a Chian," a sarcastic reference to the historian Theopompus. This remark led Alexander to order his crucifixion. He was also exiled from Chios for opposing its tyrant and wrote a violent invective against Demosthenes. Another tradition attributes his execution to Antigonos I Monophthalmus due to the "bitterness and freedom of his tongue."

No works by Theocritus survive intact. Ancient sources credit him with an **Invective against Demosthenes** and various other lost rhetorical exercises or historical writings. His output belongs to early Hellenistic rhetoric and character writing.

Theocritus represents the tradition of the outspoken intellectual who used rhetoric as a weapon against authority. His execution exemplifies the peril of free speech in the autocratic climate following the rise of Macedon. Preserved in anecdotes by Plutarch, Athenaeus, and Diogenes Laertius, he became a paradigm of caustic wit and political martyrdom in the early Hellenistic period.

Works (2)

- [Ἀπόσπασμα](#) · [Epigram Against Aristotle](#) · 1 passages
- [Ἀπόσπασμα](#) · [Epitaph for Aristotele](#) · 1 passages